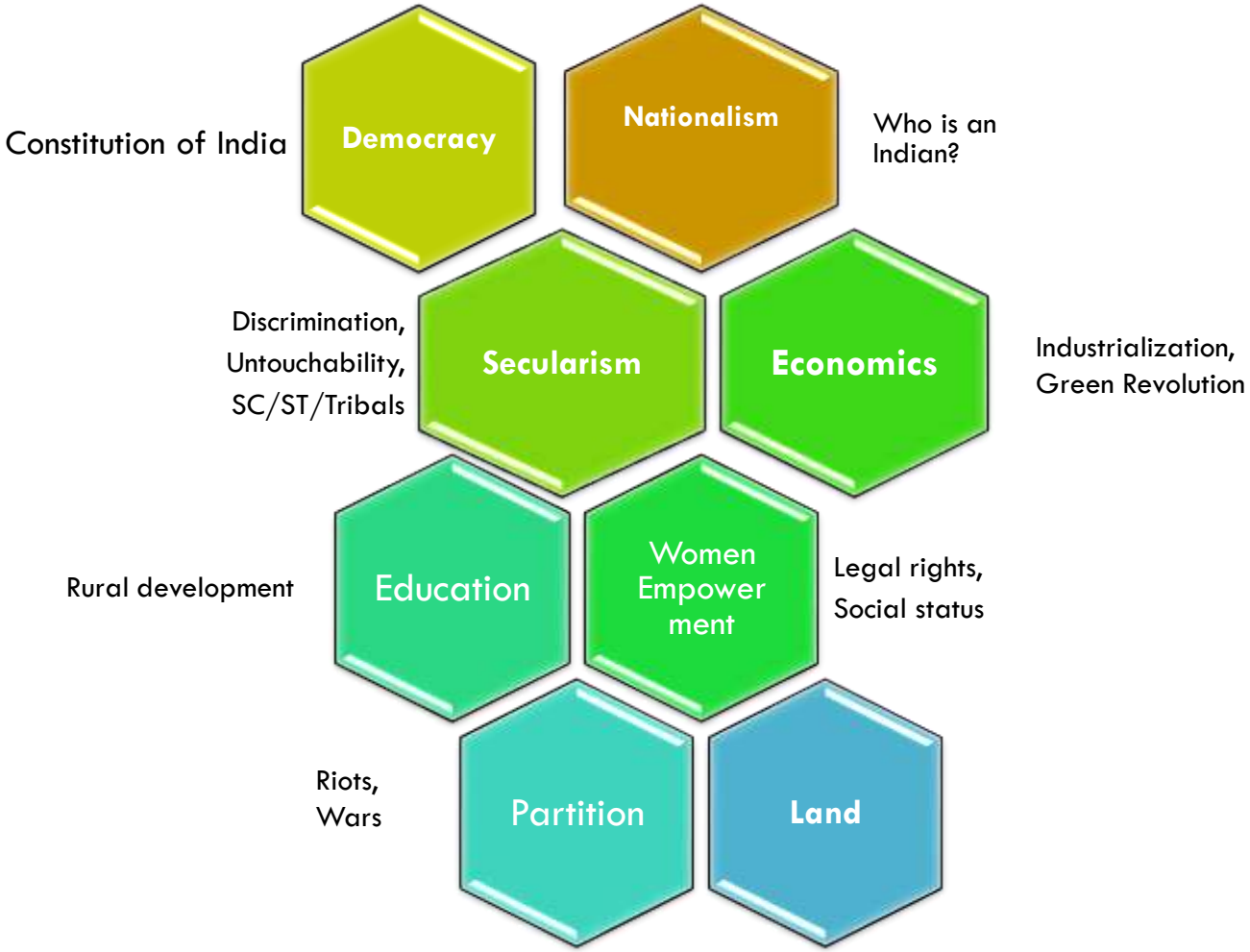
CONTEMPORARY INDIA

Unit 1

India gets Independence: Political Aspects

EMERGENCE OF INDEPENDENT INDIA

POLITICAL ASPECTS



NATIONALISM

Who am I ?

I can also be referred as per my language, religion, caste, region, gender, profession or Nationality. The answer to this question refers to one's sense and sources of identity.

What does it mean when we say that we are Indians?

A nation is usually defined as a political community with a shared history, culture, and a sense of political goals. By definition, nations are supposed to be culturally homogeneous.

If India is a nation, then how do we understand the shared history, culture, and a sense of political destiny of the 'Indians'?

There is a broad consensus among historians that the idea of the nation, the sense of national identity, and nationalism in India emerged very recently in history, and they are all products of political and cultural response by the English educated middle-class intelligentsia to the colonial rule. **Nationalism emerged as a reaction against and as a challenge to colonialism.**

Hindu Nationalism:

Hindu Nationalism in contemporary India is a variant of communal nationalism since it seeks to grant privileges to the Hindu religious community and identifies national history and culture with the history and culture understood exclusively from the perspective of the Hindu community.

The most salient components of the Hindu nationalism were developed first by V.D. Savarkar in Hindutva: Who is a Hindu? And by Golwalkar in We, Our Nation is defined. In these tracts Savarkar and Golwalkar elaborate a conception of Indian nationalism based on a specific relationship between territory, history, and culture. For Savarkar, only those persons can claim a full membership of the Indian nation who has both his fatherland (pitrubhumi) and holy land (punyabhumi) in the territory of India that he broadly equated with the territory of British India. Savarkar thus defines a Hindu as ‘ a person who regards this land of Bharatvarsha from the Indus to the seas as his pitrubhumi as well as punyabhumi that is the cradle land of his religion.

According to these territorial, religious, and genealogical criteria, Hindus, Sikhs, Jains and Buddhists can be considered the natural members of the Indian nation as all these religions were born here but not Jews, Christians and Muslims for they do not meet the religious criterion of the holy land within the territory. For the Muslims and Christians, their holy land are in Arabia or Palestine.

Secular Nationalism:

As against Communal nationalism, secular nationalism in India is born of a desire to construct an identity of Indian nationhood that recognizes the immense diversity that prevailed in India: the diversities of religion, sect, language, caste, regions etc.

How to discover a common culture in the face of so much diversity? This was a difficult task as it included the discovery of culture that would be non-sectarian, non-communal and inclusive.

Jawaharlal Nehru's Discovery of India is usually considered the foundational text of secular nationalism wherein the Indian history is told as a narrative of composite culture and unity in diversity. In this work Pluralism, syncretism, tolerance, peaceful coexistence, and composite culture appear to be main motifs. In this narrative, the heroes of Indian history are Ashoka, Kabir, Guru Nanak, Akbar, Gandhi.

The Nehruvian idea of the Indian national identity as based on composite and pluralist cultural traditions was shared by many leaders within and outside the Congress. They believed that religion could not play any important role in the political affairs of a modern society. Thus, during the last two decades of the freedom movement, mainly under the influence of Gandhi and Nehru, a pluralist identity for the Indian Nationhood emerged as a strong contender if not the dominant model. Thus politicians promoted the struggle for freedom in India as a struggle for a secular republic where all of India's inhabitants were entitled to live, irrespective of religious denomination. The events such as partition, the assassination of Mahatma Gandhi provided the background against which the post-independent Indian state adopted secularism as the principle of State policy.

DEMOCRACY

What is democracy?

Abraham Lincoln from his Gettysburg address of 1863 :" it is the government of the people, for the people and by the people."

This idea is also supported by the etymology of the word ' Democracy', which means the rule (kratos) by the people (demos). It could thus be distinguished from ' aristrocracy' which means rule by the wise; from oligarchy, which means rule by strong groups like certain families; and from monarchy, which means rule by an individual.

Democracy is identified with political quality of citizens on the basis of their equal moral status. Such a notion of equality is manifested in equal political rights for all citizens. Nevertheless, democracy has of late been formally linked to electoral aspects.

Democracy has become increasingly appealing in the modern world especially in the second half of the 20th century. The reason for that lies in the nature and functioning of the contemporary state.

The Prussian philosopher, Immaunel Kant (1724-1804), believed that if more countries across the world became democratic then there would be greater likelihood of perpetual peace because democracies have fewer chances of fighting each other. Such a belief is based on the assumption that public opinion within democratic countries would prevent their governments from going to war.

Therefore, when independent India chose democratic institutions of government, she was greeted with cheer but not without doubts about her ability to consolidate and deepen the country's newly born democratic structure.

Origins of Democracy in Independent India :

Indian democracy not only incorporates elements from Greco-Roman, French, British and American traditions but also certain indigenous aspects particular to our own culture. The preconditions for the establishment of democracy, such as, an industrialized developed economy, an ethically homogeneous population and a civic culture hospitable to democracy were all missing from the Indian scenario. Yet, the consolidation of democracy in the country, despites its many failures, is evidence of remarkable achievement of the Indian people.

Ideologically and otherwise many portions of our constitution derive from the Government of India Act 1935, which was the last major framework under which the British had ruled India till 1947. Many important features of the Indian polity are a continuation of the British political practice. These include, amongst others, the liberal-democratic nature of the Indian constitution, parliamentary form of the government, the Indian Civil Service and the Unitary character of the Indian state, whereby the emergency and residual powers lie with the central government.

However, the Indian constitution broke away from the colonial legacy in many important aspects:

In defending the Indian Constitution, *Sarvapalli Radhakrishnan* demonstrated that the republican tradition was not foreign to India, for we had it since the beginning of history. In saying so he was also arguing against the European historicist tradition, most clearly manifested in the works of John Stuart Mill. The latter had declared that Indians were not as fit to rule themselves and that the huge illiterate population was a hindrance to the implementation of adult suffrage. Dr. Radhakrishnan dismissed Mill's claim and declared that all Indians, irrespective of gender and education, were always suited for self-rule.

Consolidating Indian Democracy:

Some of the more significant features of the consolidation of Indian Democracy are: an inclusive civil service avoiding nepotism in the administrative structure, the acceptance of parliamentary democracy by major communist and socialist organizations from their initial antagonist attitudes towards electoral democracy, the decline of Congress party with its family/personality –centered rule, and military's non-interference in politics.

The outstanding phenomena of recent years in the process of democratic consolidation in India:

1. Judicial activism
2. Election commission of India
3. The new panchayati raj or the consolidation of the institutions of local governance
4. The right to information

Democratic Deepening in India:

Ever since Independence, democratic deepening has been accompanied by an attack on the hierarchies of the traditional caste system. However, it is striking that members of the marginalized castes have asserted their caste identity and have politically mobilized themselves to demand an equal status, on par with other castes rather than raising demands for the abolition of the caste system. The marginalized castes chose the term Dalit instead of the apparently patronizing term Harijan, which was introduced by Mahatma Gandhi to denominate marginalized castes.

The presence of democratic institutions is largely responsible for the growing consciousness and political mobilization of marginalized castes in their demand for equal status and equal respect. It has incorporated castes previously excluded from political power. In this context, the steady rise of the Bahujan Samaj Party founded by Kanshi Ram to represent Dalits in 1984 and claiming to be inspired by the ideas of B.R. Ambedkar is the most noteworthy case.

Critiques of Indian Democracy:

Despite the many successes attributed to Indian democracy, the state has failed in eradicating massive poverty and continuing violence against religious minorities, depressed castes, tribes and women. Economic equality had failed to be a part of debates on democracy.

Screening of Samvidhaan Series (Rajya Sabha TV)

ECONOMICS

At the time of Independence, the Indian economy was ridden with many structural constraints. The economic planners were facing a very tough task of putting the economy on the development trajectory. The problem was two-fold.

First, they needed to improve the performance of the economy in generating income and fighting poverty despite the existence of various kinds of constraints and second, these constraints had to be removed.

The prime constraints that the economy was facing were:

1. Acute shortage of physical capital in relation to the availability of employable persons.
2. The industrial sector was too weak to bring about any big turnaround.
3. The agricultural sector already had a huge surplus of unemployed or under-employed persons.
4. The agrarian economy was feudal in nature, the prime concern of which was exploitation and not the development of agriculture itself.
5. Low saving capacity of the economically drained population.
6. High rate of population
7. Situations on health, food, security, infrastructure and defense fronts was quite difficult.

India before Independence

The economic growth rate in colonial India was very low but the situation became far more serious during the first half of the 20th century. Colonial India was an agrarian economy. The national income heavily depended on the performance of agriculture, and the performance of agriculture was dependent on monsoon.

The growth prospects of industry and the tertiary sector depended on the demands for their goods and services. This demand itself depended on the agriculture sector.

It is important to note here that the Indian economy then was much more open than in the post-Independence era. Foreign trade, therefore, was an important source of demand for the industrial performance. Thus, agriculture performance was the most important cause of fluctuations in the national income.

Economic growth during British Raj

Economic growth is defined as a sustained increase in the real per capita income. This growth depends on three crucial factors, namely, availability of resources, investment and increasing efficiency. Additionally, the population growth

LAND

The land tenure system in India during the first half of the 20th century was highly exploitative. The prime goal of the zamindars was to extract maximum possible rent. Furthermore, there was a large chain of intermediaries between the state and the tiller of the land. There was economic as well as social exploitation due to the caste-based control system. The land administrative system during the colonial times exploited majority of the labor class as well as the farmer community, in general.

The last half-century of British rule in the United Provinces (17 provinces and 562 princely states) witnessed a sharp intensification of agrarian difficulties and an increasing responsiveness of the land revenue administration to political pressure.

The change in property rights benefitted the landlord class in the zamindari system, which was largely prevalent in Bihar, Bengal and Orissa whereas the changes in property rights benefitted the cultivators in the ryotwari area like Punjab and Western UP.

Interestingly, the area under ryotwari had help India usher in the green revolution.

DEMOCRATIC DECENTRALIZATION

Being such a huge and highly populated country, India felt the need for introducing democratic decentralization as a way to make democracy more sustainable. Democratic decentralization rejects the idea of a highly centralized State and replaces it with the concept of distribution of power to the people at large. In this process, the government represents a variety of people, responds to a variety of interests, and distributes power and resources in an effective manner.

People occupy the center-stage of democratic development process.

It has objectives of exploring issues like :

1. People's involvement in issues of governance
2. Accountability of the government to the people
3. Reaching the fruits of development to the people
4. Bridging the gaps of fulfillment / taking appropriate corrective measures in case of failures in the course of implementation.

PANCHAYAT RAJ

Panchayat Raj Institutions(PRI's) are not new in India. The age-old village society used to have a sort of village council which was popularly known as Panchayats. These local bodies exercised many duties to keep order in their locality. They were the last word in the internal matters of the village. They also assesses what should be the tax contribution of each villager and negotiated the village's collective tax with the king's representative.

However, during the colonial rule, the PRI's lost control and their autonomous rule was thwarted. Statutes like Indian Penal Code and Criminal Procedure Code were created by the British to replace the traditional and customary laws.

However, during the period of drafting our constitution after independence, Mahatma Gandhi voiced for decentralization structure of a self-sufficient village republic. However, Ambedkar and his supporters felt that only a strong, centralized State could deliver developmental services to all segments of society.

Balwantrai. Mehta committee studied the possibility of re-establishing Panchayati Raj Institutions in India. His recommendations led to the formation of the PRI's all over the country.

While distributing powers between Union and States, the Constitution referred to Panchayats as a subject under the jurisdiction od states. Article 40 (Directive Principles of State Policy) stated that the State shall take steps to organize village panchayats and endow them with powers and authority as may be necessary to enable them to function as units of self-government.